

Design Assignment – AI Platform to Connect Brands to Influencers

Executive Summary

This project proposes a two-sided platform that connects micro-influencers with brands, offering end-to-end support including influencer-brand matching, contracts, payments, tax handling, and analytics. Unlike enterprise-focused competitors, it differentiates itself by focusing specifically on micro-creators and smaller brands, providing affordable, accessible, and compliant tools. This design document outlines the idea, competitor analysis, stakeholders, and two user journeys (influencer and brand) to demonstrate how the platform balances stakeholder values and delivers a seamless experience.

The Idea: A Two-Sided Micro-Influencer Platform

The project is a two-sided platform connecting brands with micro-influencers (e.g., Instagram and TikTok). It provides end-to-end collaboration support: influencer matching, contracts, payments, tax compliance, and analytics. This helps micro-creators monetize their content while giving brands access to authentic audiences in a streamlined, compliant way.

Similar Existing Services and Differentiation

A number of influencer marketing platforms already exist:

- **Aspire (AspireIQ):** Offers end-to-end influencer relationship management, but is geared towards mid-to-large brands with higher budgets.
- **GRIN:** Positions itself as an “all-in-one creator management platform,” with influencer CRM, contract workflows, and automated payments, but pricing and complexity are often prohibitive for small brands or micro-creators.
- **Creator.co:** Provides a campaign marketplace and centralizes content, payments, and analytics, but mainly serves brands looking for scale rather than tailored micro-influencer engagements.
- **JoinBrands:** A marketplace connecting thousands of TikTok and Instagram micro-creators to brands. Focuses heavily on product seeding and low-budget campaigns but offers less support around contracts and compliance.

- **Collabstr:** Marketplace where influencers list their services and brands can directly book collaborations, but lacks integrated tools for taxes, escrow payments, and structured analytics.
- **Influential.co:** An AI-driven platform focused on enterprise brands and macro-influencers. It excels in data integrations and advanced audience targeting but is expensive and inaccessible to smaller players.

Differentiation – Why This Idea, Why Now:

Our platform focuses exclusively on micro-influencers and smaller brands, providing a comprehensive, affordable, and compliance-friendly solution. Unlike enterprise-focused tools, our design lowers barriers to entry (simple onboarding, transparent pricing, low campaign minimums). Unlike marketplaces that only connect brands and influencers, our platform manages the entire workflow — matching, contracts, secure escrow payments, tax documentation, and campaign analytics.

This is timely because:

1. **Market shift:** Brands are 10× more likely to work with micro-influencers than celebrities, valuing authenticity and ROI.
2. **Technology readiness:** Escrow payment systems, fintech APIs, and AI-based matching are mature and can now be offered cheaply at scale.
3. **Regulatory clarity:** Clear FTC disclosure and tax reporting requirements allow us to bake compliance into the product design.

By combining these factors, our platform fills the gap left between lightweight marketplaces (too simple) and enterprise tools (too complex and costly), creating the right-sized solution for micro-influencers and small-to-mid-sized brands.

Stakeholder Analysis

- **Micro-Influencers (Users):** Value fair pay, ease of use, creative freedom. Motivated to monetize content. Expect transparency, timely payments, and contract/tax support.
- **Brands (Customers):** Value ROI, efficiency, and compliance. Motivated to find authentic voices and measure campaign success. Expect robust search, analytics, and brand safety.

- **Platform Owners:** Value growth and sustainability. Motivated to balance user satisfaction with revenue.
 - **Investors:** Value market growth and monetization. Motivated to scale quickly.
 - **Regulators:** Value compliance (FTC ad disclosures, tax reporting). Motivated to protect consumers and enforce laws.
 - **Employees:** Value stability and alignment with mission. Motivated to build and maintain a fair ecosystem.
 - **Others:** Agencies/managers may use or compete with the platform. Social platforms (Instagram, TikTok) influence the ecosystem with policies and APIs.
-

User Journey: Micro-Influencer (Primary User)

Persona: Alex, a 22-year-old fitness micro-influencer with 8k Instagram followers.

1. **Onboarding:** Alex signs up, links her Instagram/TikTok, and fills out payment/tax info. She values quick setup and transparency, though compliance paperwork is a minor hassle.
2. **Discovering Opportunities:** She browses the campaign marketplace and applies filters. The platform recommends a vegan protein brand campaign that fits her profile.
3. **Collaboration Setup:** Alex applies, gets accepted, and signs a pre-filled contract with deliverables, deadlines, and \$300 escrowed payment. She appreciates payment security and clear terms.
4. **Content Creation:** She creates a Reel, uploads it for review, and negotiates small edits (product visibility vs. authenticity). The platform's workflow keeps revisions simple.
5. **Publication:** Alex posts approved content with #ad disclosure. She balances compliance with her desire for high engagement.
6. **Payment:** The platform releases \$300 from escrow to her bank account, logs earnings, and prepares tax records.
7. **Feedback & Analytics:** Both Alex and the brand leave ratings. She receives campaign performance stats, boosting her credibility for future collaborations.

Values tensions: creative freedom vs. brand control, fast payments vs. platform fees, authenticity vs. regulatory compliance.

User Journey: Brand (Customer)

Persona: **SuperVega**, a small vegan protein startup.

1. **Onboarding:** SuperVega registers, creates a brand profile, and adds billing details. They value a smooth process without needing agency support.
2. **Campaign Creation:** They create a campaign brief: 1 Reel + 1 Story, \$300 budget, hashtags, and audience niche. The platform suggests budget ranges to ensure competitiveness.
3. **Discovering Influencers:** Using filters, they review candidates. The system recommends Alex, whose profile and engagement fit their needs.
4. **Collaboration Setup:** They accept Alex's application, sign the contract, and deposit \$300 in escrow. They value automated compliance and payment security.
5. **Content Review:** Alex submits her draft Reel. SuperVega requests a clearer product shot, which Alex incorporates. The revision is approved.
6. **Campaign Launch:** Alex posts the content with required disclosures. The platform verifies publication and compliance automatically.
7. **Payment & Analytics:** The platform releases escrowed funds. SuperVega receives engagement and ROI data, confirming campaign success and informing future campaigns.

Values tensions: brand consistency vs. influencer authenticity, ROI focus vs. fair creator compensation, compliance enforcement vs. influencers' concern about engagement.

Edited and formatted with Gen AI